The Greenwood Cycle

By Ai

(after the events surrounding the Tulsa Riots)

The Sheriff's Explanation

I deputized a lot of men that day.
I didn't say, "Are you men in the Klan,"
when they raised their hands
and swore to uphold the law.
All I cared about was whether they were willing to die.
If they did so in the service of the white race,
I could live with that.
I could not live with the disgrace
of allowing Negroes to get away
with rape, murder and worse.
If we didn't stop them now, I thought,
we'd have to later.
Yes, innocent died,
depending on how you look at it.
You couldn't tell who was what.

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Miss Mary, old woman
used to cook dinner for us
when I was a boy
got caught in the middle of gunfire.
I drug her body out of the way of trampling feet,
least I could do,
but see, she was one of them . . . . .

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INTRODUCTION

The history of the United States has produced much in the way of race riots, from the New York City riots of 1862 to the Los Angeles riots of 1991, this country has experienced much civil unrest between blacks and whites. However, the Tulsa Race Riot of 1921 was perhaps the costliest incident of racial violence in American history. At the same time, it is perhaps the most marginalized, being almost forgotten until this decade.

On the morning of May 30, 1921, a young black man named Dick Rowland was riding in at Tulsa elevator. The white elevator operator, Sarah Page, claimed that Rowland grabbed her arm, causing her to flee in panic. Whispers of "assault and rape" were circulated in the local papers.

Tulsa police arrested Rowland the following day and began an investigation. a confrontation between black and white armed mobs around the courthouse soon ensued. Talk of lynching began, but the black were determined to prevent another such incident. Shots were fired and the outnumbered blacks began retreating to the Greenwood

Avenue business district.

In the early morning hours of June 1, 1921, Black Tulsa was looted and burned by white rioters. Twenty-four hours after the violence erupted, it ceased. In the wake of the violence, 35 city blocks lay in charred ruins, over 800 people were treated for injuries and there were estimated reports of 300 deaths.

Ai in her poem The Greenwood Cycle brings this historic event to life in a series of poetic monologues to show this racial violence through the eyes of members of Tulsa' black community.

The Greenwood Cycle by Ai.

Conjure

I thought I was dreaming

when I saw the sky fulla black smoke,

but I wasn't, no, 'cause I pinched myself

and it hut

and I knew we were gonna suffer

for somebody's sinfulness.

"Just like Jesus," you said, Mama,

when you screamed,

"Run, daughter, run,

white men are comin', they got guns."

I said, "I see 'em, Mama I see,

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they ridin' up and down the street

throwin' torches on rooftops, on porches,

on the poor Negro trying to pray

while the flames eat him up

they so hungry.

Mama, we can't get away."

"Run on, daughter," you cried, "hide if you can

from the white devil,"

but he wasn't no devil, he was a man

and he was evil, yes, he was,

but he wasn't supernatural,

he didn't have no power to conjure like I do,

when I conjure you,

crying, "Don't look back, or you'll turn to ashes

and fall down among the dead in Greenwood."

Now I'm alone

and I don't say nothing 'bout it to nobody,

just fix me a hot toddy

and sit rocking in my rocker

and think about you, Mama,

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turned to dust
wrapped in a dirty sheet
with a body lying on top.
"It ain't Christian, is it," you whisper
"to be murdered like this and just forgot?"
I rock in time to the ticktock of the grandfather clock
you dragged from the burning house,
because it was your daddy's,
give to him by the old master
when your daddy got freedom.
For some reason, it didn't burn up
just charred a bit,
a piece of wood pried off it.
When I got up the money,
I went and bought it off the junkman
who thought it was worth something.
It was, but only to me,
rusted, permanently stopped
at the hour and the minute
that cost me you.

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Sanctuary

"Is the world on fire?"
--Sister of Mr. Beard, survivor

I said, "Brother, the world's on fire."
He said, "Liar,"
but Daddy said, "Y'all climb up on higher
in that tree so only God can see you,
not me, or the white man running thisa way,
guns blazing, burning up everything.
Can't see nothing through the smoke,
can't breathe, choking like I got two hands
around my throat.
Je-e-e-sus, Je-e-e-sus."
"Brother," I whispered, and he said, "Hush,"
as a hot wind rustled the leaves
and the white man ran past,
screaming something about niggers and too much --
"What'd he say, brother?" I asked,
but he turned away.
"Lookayonder," I heard him say,
just as a loud crack and a popping sound

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got mixed up in my head.
When I climbed down that old tree, I said,
"Brother, are you dead?"
He just stared at me,
then outta nowhere someone grabbed my hair.
Daddy had braided it for me that morning
and tied a ribbon on it
and said, "I'm warning you don't take it off,"
and I didn't, but it come off anyway,
when the hand jerked too hard
and got a fist fulla red ribbon
and I started running myself.
Wasn't nobody else but me around after 'while
in the dark, back in the back of somebody's house,
I mean underneath it,
where a dog was hiding too.
It was a hound dog with two pups.
You know how mean a new mother can be,
but she didn't growl or nothing,
just gave me the eye
and went on back to nursing

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and didn't do nothing when I got real close
and stroked her fur and closed my eyes.
I woke to her sighs.
The pups' eyes weren't open yet,
but they moved their heads
when I started to crawl outta hiding,
but then I heard crying, I heard a shot
and moved on back
and got close to the dog and those pups.
I knew from that moment on
I was hound Mary's daughter
and I would never leave.

The Rescue

I seen trouble coming from a long way off.
I seen it this morning in a bubble of blood
when I cut my finger on that cup I broke.
Nobody had to tell me about it.
I could see things. I had second sight.
Got it from Mama, a full-blooded Cherokee.
"Son," she'd say, "you got one foot in Heaven

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the other in Hell
Trouble gonna find you
wherever you dwell.
It's gonna come in fire.
I know secrets I better not tell
and you will too, when the time comes."
Here it is –
a Negro boy running fast as he can
a white man behind him
with a noose in his hand.
My daddy was Negro too.
Should I do something 'cause halfa me
could also swing from a tree?
I don't know what to do
til I remember Mama telling me
about the long walk
when so many people died on the Trail of Tears.
She said the old folks told her
nobody could believe Andrew Jackson
would make them leave their home, but he did.
the white man takes what he gives.

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He's got two faces and both of them smile
while he plans your destruction.
"He don't like Indians, but he hates Negroes," she said.
"You got looks and hair like your mother
you're lucky that way,
defer to the white man, stay out of his path."
"But I can't Mama," I say out loud,
"Can't let a child die like this.
It ain't right, is it?"
She answered, all right,
well, it was the wind,
but it was her voice talking through it.
I got in the wagon, all hitched 'cause I was going
somewhere
and turned my mules in the path
where the white man was running and stopped there.
Gave that boy enough time to hide someplace.
White man cursed, pointed his gun at me.
"Sorry Mister, "I said,
"these mules got minds of their own."
"Ain't you part nigger?" he said to me,,

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Then he shot my mules.
I knew he'd die in his sleep.
I saw the sowing he'd reap
and that released me from my hatred.
I buried Brandy and Brandywine
took a long time, said a few words.
One day, that boy came to see me.
He had a scar running down one side of his face.
He said, "Mister, I'm cold and hungry,
can I stay at your place?"
I said, "Yes, come on in the kitchen where it's warm.
Lemme look at your face.
Maybe I got something that'll help,"
but he said, "Nothing will."
I filled his plate with pinto beans, bacon, cornbread,
filled his glass of milk to the brim,
then we said grace.
"Where's your mama?" I asked
and he said, "Dead,
Yours?"
"Same. Pitiful, isn't it?

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You aim to move on, or stay?"
"Don't you know?" he asked
I said, "Some things, not others."
He said, "Your mother was a witch,
that's what people say."
"Naw, she wasn't, she just saw things."
"I ain't too black for you?"
"I am too, " I said
"No, you ain't," he answered,
"but you'll do."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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